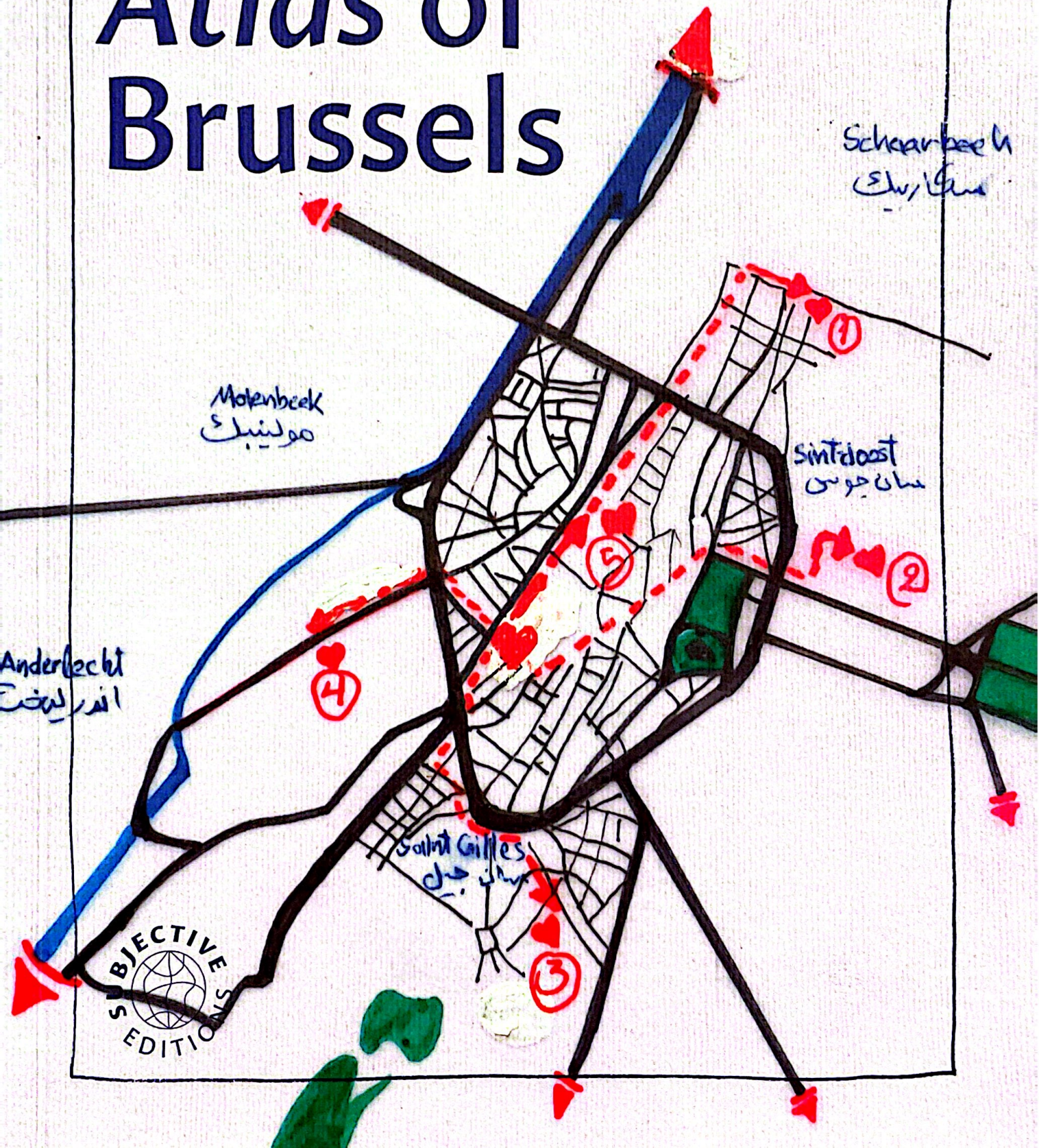


Subjective Atlas of Brussels



Proposition

To start with, I immediately regret writing in English. Brussels is about a lot of things, and certainly about the many different languages, cultures and backgrounds. [It's the capital of diverse entities and can't be captured as a singularity, nor in a single image. Nevertheless, the representation of Brussels has recently become rather uniform. The terrorist attacks, the political turmoil and the throngs of journalists in Molenbeek pushed the narrative of the city far away from its reality on the ground.]

Having lived in Brussels for more than 10 years now and having fallen in love with this undefinable metropolis, [I keep being surprised by people I meet elsewhere in Belgium who have rarely travelled to Brussels or who consider it a dangerous place to live in.] I wonder whether it has to do with the fact that it's often outsiders who speak about Brussels, or whether it's the savage dynamics of mass media, contiguously highlighting the exception, magnifying problems and capturing the temporality. Or [is it the lack of diversity in the representative bodies, whether the city council or cultural institutes? The profound involvement of the residents in the development of the city and their experience of living here are aspects that remain underexposed in the media spectacle.]

In this *Subjective Atlas*, more than 80 creative individuals visualized their view. What does it mean to be or to live in Brussels? What are the urgencies of the citizens? What are the particular qualities? Based on their own personal experiences and observations, they mapped out what makes life worth living here. From quay views ^{page 44} to high-rise-perspectives ^{page 48}, from alternative playgrounds ^{page 108} to the last rays of sunshine ^{page 100} and from damaged bollards ^{page 60} to places of hope ^{page 124}. Over the course of several workshops and many encounters, the contributors captured their engagement in maps, inventories and drawings. [Each work stems from involvement with the subjects and takes an engaged, critical and transparent position, not a neutral or so-called objective one. As such, the contributions not only show their own story, but also develop meta-reflections on contemporary forms of living together and community building.]

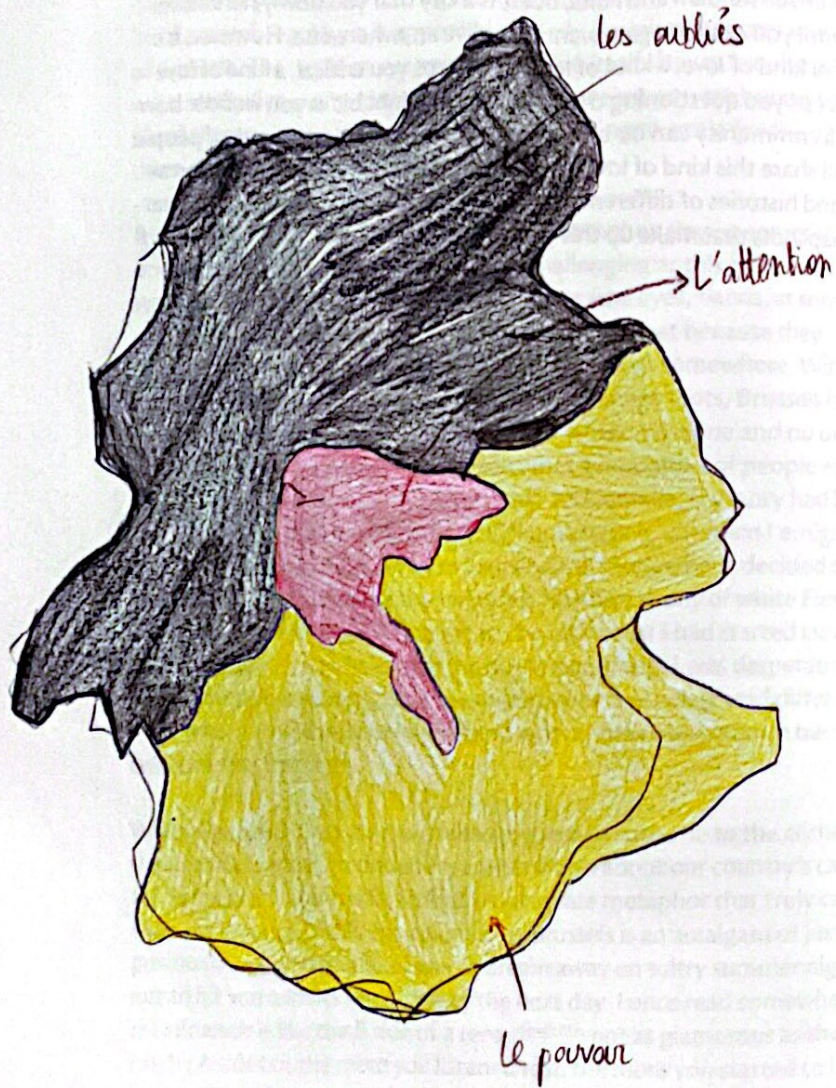
This creative trajectory illustrates how design can be an important tool for soft power and how it helps to imagine a different future. The *Subjective Atlas* is therefore also a proposition for a creative mentality that is politically engaged, socially sensitive, collaborative in nature and transdisciplinary in its method.]

Overall the book offers a platform for a bottom-up polyphonic visual dialogue about Brussels at this moment of time. I hope it can contribute to a better representation and understanding of a city with enormous potential. It's not an easy reality, nor a simple love. But one that is intense and enriching and one that can be life-changing. Brussels has taught me more about the world than any other city. It's a society that we can never capture, never fully understand or control. But it challenges us to find new languages to speak about who we are and what binds us.

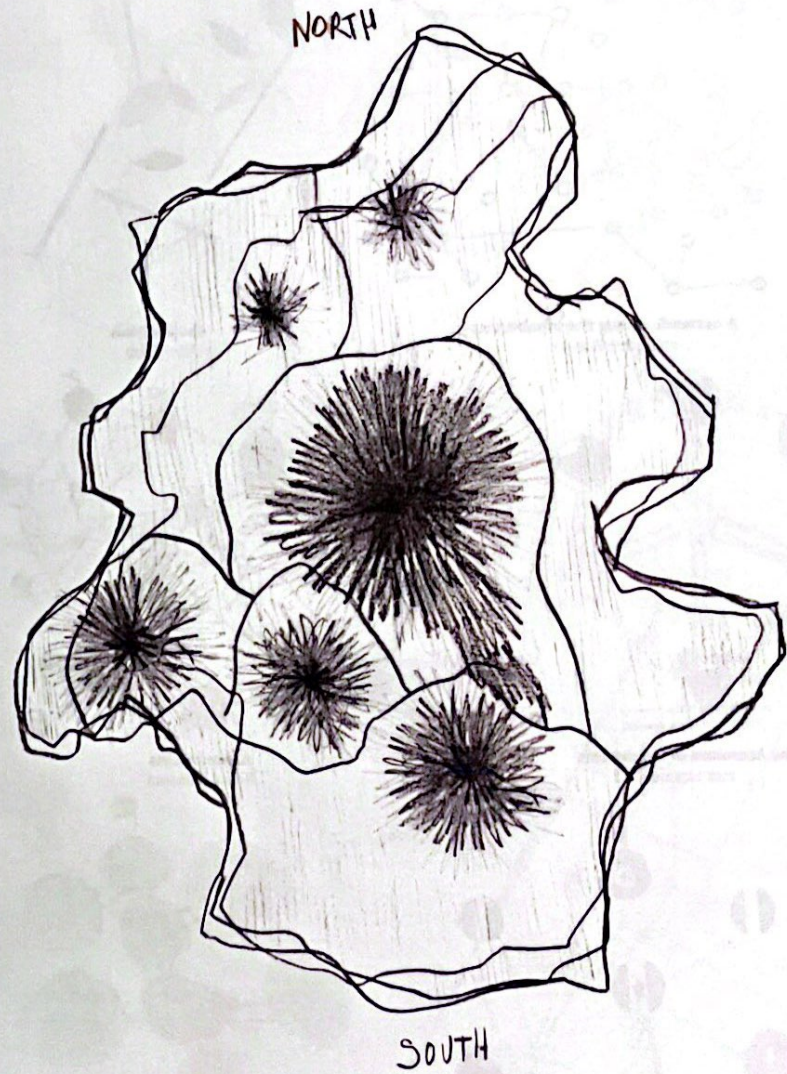
I deeply want to thank all artists, designers, architects and creative minds who have generously contributed to this *Subjective Atlas* – taking pictures in the middle of the night, travelling to each commune, crossing borders, measuring distances and stretching their perspectives. It's through their accumulative voices that this Atlas wants to reclaim agency to the city's narrative.

It's not
3
positionality

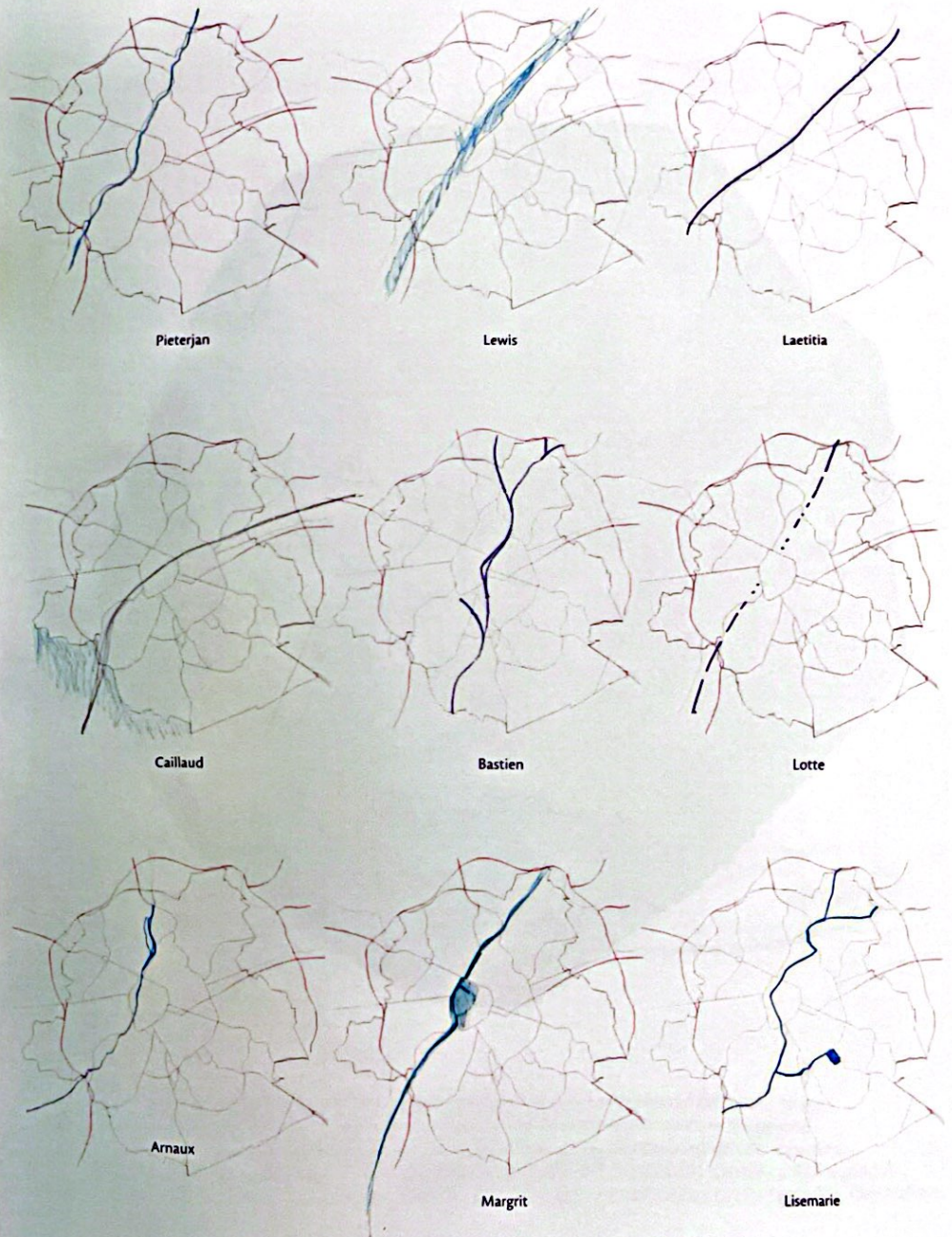
Don't write
ourselves out



The challenge
Amina Saâdi



Cities in the city
Amina Saâdi



LESBIAN BARS

128

A puzzle of hearsay about bars, cafés and regular parties for lesbians in Brussels, in approximate chronology. The hearsay and hearts are gathered during the ongoing research of Brussels Almanack Lesbian (BAL).



129

Hetero guys could pay extra to be allowed to stare at or touch lesbians. Sometimes we actually danced them out! Pushed them back out onto the street by just taking back the dancefloor. There was a feeling of freedom to kick them out!

Very dark, but more open as a space.

Chic!

Fancy, more expensive. To enter you had to know the number and which doorbell to ring, which was secret. However, you also had to write your full name and address in a register! I told all the young lesbians to write fake names. The place was not politically critical, but commercial, and so it felt wrong that they had a list of our names.

At the back a dark room that wasn't a dark room...

Good music. A self-determined resistance inside the LGBT scene. Saw myself as a moving star. Mixed. Very queer.

Oh the boat! 'no-man's-land'

They invited bands, it was a lot of fun.

I wouldn't say 800, I would say 400. But they were big.

All black everything. People did not want to be recognized. No funny lights, very sombre. I couldn't exist in it, it was terrible that way. It did not feel like home. It was located in a remote street, and you had to know when it was open. That was risky. But some people were just happy it existed at all.

It was about taking up public space. There was a piano, there were events, lectures. The bar had a big mirror behind it, and above that hung a very large portrait of Virginia Wolf.

We called the owner 'Mae West'.

Very dark.

Where the lesbian magazine *De Paarse Peperpot* first started.

Too hardcore.

It had a mix of men and women. And a lot of 'prostitutes'. Non-professional prostitutes.

Sociologically it was great. All the female bus- and tram-conductors at the time were lesbians, and they had these very femme girlfriends that would come to the bar just after midnight to wait for their butch partners to finish work. Also it was the first time I saw someone in a wheelchair in a bar. Yes the bar was dodgy, but it was also inclusive and open.

The last place for a long while that was not mainly commercial but took care of the community. There were a lot of lesbian regulars.

A man with a moustache would stand guard at the door. You had to pay him as you went out, for protection. He was often together with a blonde woman who would always make sure you had a drink.

A reaction against the small bars. Large lesbian parties were organized, forming a club that used the membership cards to avoid the police. The law protected us, but the police didn't. The gays would follow the trend. It was always like that. We were runaways and outcasts, always creating new types of social spaces.

It was inclusive. I would be there at 5 in the morning and a group of Moroccan girls would come dancing for example. We didn't have many places like that.

Ah, yes, Carieneke's place.

late 1950s ♥ **la Pergola**
late 1960s ♥ **Unnamed café in Loofstraat**

1980-82? ♥ **Elle (later Amfora)**

ca 1978 ♥ **Lilith**

ca 1978 ♥ **Liever Eva**

parties ca 1979 ♥ **Homo-L**

early 1980s ♥ **Black Swan**

early 1980s ♥ **Le Chewing-gum bar?**

early 1980s ♥ **Le Cercle?**

around 1985 ♥ **Lady June (café)**

Wednesdays 1987 ♥ **De Kluts**

1990?-94 ♥ **Le Capricorne**

12 11 1981-83 ♥ **Madam / Le Madam Club**

01 08 1982-? ♥ **Amfora (old Elle)**

♥ **L'Evenement**

♥ **La Lune**

1990-97? ♥ **Le Féminin**

1990 ♥ **Sappho**

around 1990 ♥ **Diamant Rose**

around 1990 ♥ **Club Radical?**

monthly 1995-98 ♥ **La Peniche**

around 1998 ♥ **Sapho**

1995-1999 ♥ **D-LIGHT / Pussy Galore**

Parties ca 1999 ♥ **Les Biches**

♥ **The Big Noise**

♥ **Womania**

♥ **Wings**

♥ **Le Bistrot Lesbien**

ca 2000 ♥ **Lespace**

2000-2003 ♥ **Gate**

1999-2003 ♥ **Rainbow House**

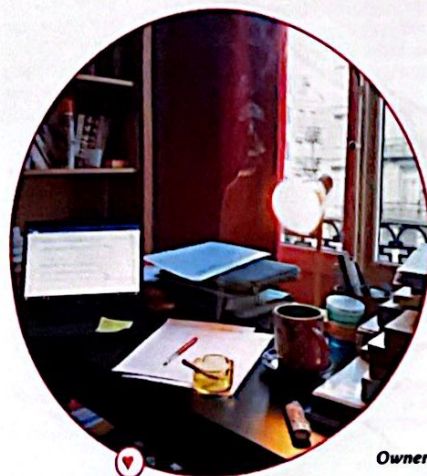
2001-ongoing ♥ **Mothers & Daughters**

May-June 2018 ♥ **Mothers & Daughters**

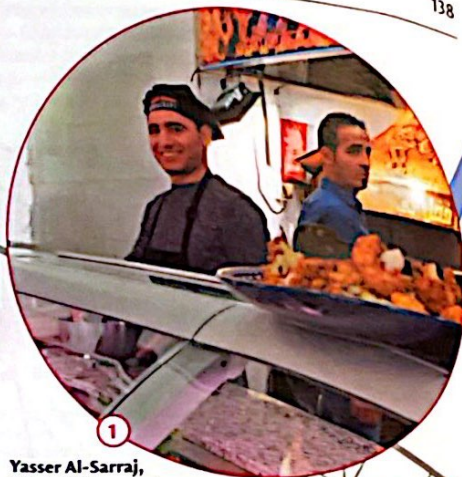
The Bistro, it was almost a discussion group. A place for philosophy and reflection.

One of the most important (impressive) parties I ever saw. At the time we must have had the biggest lesbian parties in Europe. There were 800 lesbians.

A reaction against the small bars. Large lesbian parties were organized, forming a club that used the membership cards to avoid the police. The law protected us, but the police didn't. The gays would follow the trend. It was always like that. We were runaways and outcasts, always creating new types of social spaces.



Saraa Saleh, Academic, artist
1000, Brussels
Brussels, like Damascus, cannot be neutral and my relationship with them cannot be serene. To really live in such a city means to be engaged with it in a passionate and yet complex relationship.



Yasser Al-Sarraj,
Owner of Bab Al-Hara restaurant
1070, Anderlecht
Dear Brussels, I came to you from the eastern coast of the Mediterranean, to you I present the most delightful inventions of this coast.

Mahmoud Saber, Nuts shopkeeper
1070, Anderlecht
In Syria, roasting, flavouring and mixing nuts is considered an art, not a profession.



Emad Karkokly, Sweets shopkeeper
1000, Brussels
The sweetest of Damascus in the heart of Brussels.



Kito Sino, Artist
1030, Schaerbeek
Everywhere I went, I carried Brussels with me and left a part of it behind.



Katia Al Jbrail,
Sr Specialist Regulatory Oversight Management
1060, Saint-Gilles
Brussels, my love, I know your lanes as I know the lines in the palm of my hand.



Angela Al-Souliman, Video artist
1210, Saint-Josse
Brussels, I will blossom in you as the jasmine blossoms in a Syrian spring.